

ESSENCE OF BASIC EDUCATION

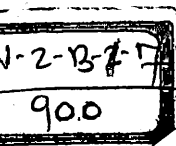
By
Vinoba

Extracts from writings and talks

Compiled by
K. S. ACHARLU

**SARVODAYA PRACHURALAYA
THANJAVUR**

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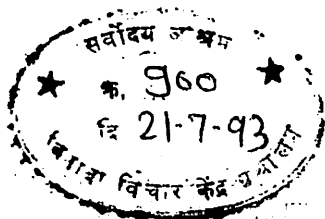


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सर्वोदय विभाग



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Compiler's Note

This pamphlet contains the cream of Vinoba's educational thought, in the form of simple aphorisms, framed from out of his addresses and talks delivered on various occasions during the Bhoodan and Gramdan Yatra. If the beauty of the Hindi original idiom has not been brought out in this translation, the fault is entirely that of the compiler-translator's.

An attempt has been made here to group the ideas of Vinoba according to subject matter, so as to present continuity of thinking on various educational ideas. A few significant Sanskrit and Hindi words of original addresses have been retained in the text. They are explained in the glossary of terms at the end.

The compiler feels that this pamphlet will provoke thought among the educationists on the vital issues which have been presented.

Bangalore
6-6-67 }

K. S. Acharlu

Glossary of Hindi and Sanskrit words

atma vikas	—Self-development, growth of personality
adhyayan	—learning, study
agrani	—vanguard, foremost leader
ahimsa	—non-violence, love
ananda	—bliss, joy, delight
apurna	—incomplete, not full
ashram	—a hermitage in which the preceptors and pupils lived together
atma gyan	—knowledge of self
atma Vikas	—self-development, growth of personality
Bhagavad Gita	—Celestial song; the philosophical song in which the Lord spoke to Arjuna
Brahma Vidya	—Philosophy of Existence
Chitta shuddhi	—Purity of mind
Ekagrata	—intentness of one subject
gathuvit	—a singer, a man of vision
gramdan	—offering of a village
guru	—teacher
Gurukula	—a residential community of preceptors and pupils
jeevan sikshan	—education for life
Jnan	—knowledge
khadi	—hand spun and hand woven cloth
karma	—work, bodily occupation or activity
lokaneethi	—the people's will
mahavidyalaya	—adult and social education institution
marga darshak	—path finder
Nai Talim	—new education, basic education
namratva	—humility
nitya nai talim	—ever new education
pada yatra	—going on foot from place to place
paisa	—the smallest indian coin
parisrama alaya	—occupational institution, craft-work institution
rama rajya	—an ideal state of peace and happiness
samatva	—equality, impartiality, fairness
sarva dharma sama bhava	—equal reverence for all religions
sat sangh	—association of good people
sat sankalpa	—virtuous resolve
seva vritti	—attitude of social service
srama nishta	—faith in manual work; devotion to manual occupations
subha chintan	—thinking of good thoughts
swaraj	—independence
swavalamban	—self-sufficiency
udyog	—occupation, craft
vanaprastha	—the third stage of life when one has to get rid of domestic responsibilities
vinaya	—discipline, decency, conduct in general
vyasana	—bad practices, evil ways

THE ESSENCE OF BASIC EDUCATION

1. Educational Reconstruction, the first task after Swaraj :

Education should have been the first thing to have been planned for after Swaraj.

The old system of education should not have been continued even for a day.

There should have been a reconstruction in education immediately after Swaraj.

Gandhiji planned for education of the country long before the attainment of Swaraj.

Our country had eminent educationists whose doctrines and educational experiments should have acted as our guide.

2. Education in Indian tradition :

Indian tradition gave the highest place to education, and the topmost importance to the teacher, the Acharya.

The State provided all facilities to the Ashram and left him full freedom in the matter of education and its organisation.

The authority of the State in matters of syllabus and text books was never heard of in olden days.

In the gurukula, the prince and the pauper were educated together. They had to do manual labour in addition to study (adhyayan).

The teacher's advice was sought by kings and emperors.

The teacher spread his influence all over the land, and he was the progenitor of social and moral revolution.

A great variety and richness of thinking prevailed in the gurukulas.

The best treatise on education is the Bhagavad Gita.

3 Principles of Nai Talim :

(a) Education should be revolutionized so as to bring an integration of jnan and karma. (knowledge and action).

Karma and jnan should be integrated in the individual. This will result in the integration of personality and will contribute to the establishment of harmony in society.

Education is the integration of Jnan and Karma, resulting in ananda, joy.

Karma and Jnan are not two different entities, one superior or inferior to the other. Nai Talim is based on the unity of karma and jnan.

The most natural method of acquiring knowledge is through karma. No knowledge without action, and no action without knowledge.

Mental and physical work are essential for everyone. All the faculties should be developed as a harmonious whole.

In education the separation of jnan and karma is resolved. Through their harmony, atmavikas is obtained.

Education should consist of Brahmavidya and udyog. The one feeds the soul and the other the body.

(b) Nai Talim cannot be pursued keeping the social order of today as it is. Nai Talim is based on the principle of bread labour. It is a revolution in social values. It is meant to create a new social order.

A new social order is impossible of achievement without the integration of work and knowledge.

A healthy society should not be divided into "heads" and "hands". Separation of learning from labour results in social injustice.

One of the chief principles of this new order is that everyone should do manual labour for his sustenance. Otherwise it results in exploitation.

Nai Talim proposes to root out this exploitation.

Nai Talim aims at establishing new values in society.

(c) Nai Talim is education for non-violence. It is founded on freedom and mutual cooperation. It ought to enable the students to claim that it can protect the country through ahimsaic methods.

The goal of the new education is freedom from fear.

(d) Education should result in swavalamban—for bodily needs, for independent critical thinking and acquiring complete knowledge and for spiritual development.

The main end of Nai Talim is the development of character.

(e) Education should develop social consciousness among the students, the attitudes and habits of doing work in cooperation with others.

Education is necessary for the proper functioning of democracy.

The social principle of Nai Talim is that all human lives are equally to be respected.

(f) Real education is service of man.

(g) Education should be intimately related to life and nature.

The student should have intimate contact with nature and be in harmony with it.

Knowledge of the natural environment is essential.

Life without association of agriculture is incomplete (apurna). We have to be in touch with land, rooted to the soil.

It helps us to be one with creation.

(h) The schools should be organised on the model of a good family.

(i) Education is impossible in an environment of ease and comfort.

The goal of education is discipline, not self-indulgence but self-control.

(j) Nai Talim is a never-ending continuous process, always fresh.

It is not stale, stereotyped and standardized.

It varies from day to day and from region to region.

It is nitya Nai Talim.

(k) Nai Talim is not meant for the elementary grades only. It is the character of all education.

It is not meant only for the villages, but for everyone at all stages of life.

(l) Nai Talim is not an educational method.

It is not "activity education".

It is not an educational technique like the Dalton method or the Project method.

It is a creative idea, a way of life.

It is a new outlook, a new approach.

4. Udyog :

Schools should be parishramalayas.

Parishrama-nishta (devotion to work) should be developed in them.

Work is labour ; work is service ; work is joy and worship.

Physical labour helps to keep the mind fresh and creative and sharpens the intellect.

Through Udyog the scientific attitudes of thinking should be developed

Nai Talim is not craft education. It is the full development of human potentialities.

A student should not only be an expert in craft, but have the capacity to study and explain scientifically all the processes.

Efficiency in udyog will be reached when the pupil has the courage and confidence to say that working for four hours a day he can feed his body.

Through craft three objectives are realized ; the allround development of all the faculties, acquisition of knowledge useful in life, acquiring skills for living.

Physical development must be obtained through craft.

Craft work should develop the power of steady application.

In Nai Talim schools, how much money is earned should not be the criterion. Agriculture produces not money but grain, vegetables and fruit. Carpentry produces not money but useful articles for the home and the community.

If all students in the country devote half an hour for spinning everyday throughout the year, the production of national wealth (khadi) will be enormous.

China's educational method of half-time academic work and half-time productive work in all schools is worthy of emulation.

In all children, the doing-type of experiences have to be encouraged.

5. The Teacher :

(a) Indian tradition gives the highest place to the teacher, the acharya.

The State provided him all facilities and left him free to conduct education.

The teacher was a margadarsak, gathuvit.

(b) Today the teacher is not a guru, an acharya, but a servant. His advice is hardly asked for.

(c) The teacher should be the torch-bearer of freedom and independent thinking

He should not be a slave of the State.

(d) The teacher is the architect of the new social order, of a social and moral revolution for the establishment of new values in society.

(e) The teacher should be a model of simplicity and clean life.

He should be free from all vyasanās.

He should be devoted to adhyāyan.

He should be an expert in the craft he teaches.

He should be a swavalambi and have faith in Udyog.

The teacher and the pupil should work together.

In working with children the teacher should grow young like them.

The teacher should not attach himself to party-politics though he should acquire a full knowledge of politics and political problems.

(f) The teacher in the village should not only be an educator of children but should assume leadership of the village.

He can wield tremendous influence in the village and can shape the government of the country, provided he is free from party-politics and exercises his freedom.

He is the agrani and gramani of the village.

He should be the guide, philosopher and friend of the village.

Let a teacher see to it that not a single dispute goes to the law courts from the village.

Let the villagers feel the pulse of Ramarajya through the teacher.

(g) A teacher should be given a piece of land for his cultivation, and all the members of his family should be a part of the school.

The teacher's wife should share his work.

All teachers should receive the same salary.

The teacher may work for two hours with students, two hours for the village, and two hours in the field.

(h) The vanaprastha is the best teacher. Vanaprasthas with ripe experience in the fields of industry, commerce, politics etc should be appointed as teachers and professors in schools and colleges. Young and inexperienced persons should not be entertained as professors and teachers.

The vanaprasthas with their wives should be teachers.

(i) The teacher in Nai Talim should be pupil-oriented, the student should be education-oriented and both be devoted to the acquisition of knowledge and service.

(j) A teacher is not simply an instructor. He can at best educate about ten pupils. Classes of 50 or 100 students are a mob.

(k) The training of teachers should consist of actual work in the field and workshop.

(l) Experienced teachers should handle lower standards.

6. Medium of Instruction and Language :

Mother tongue can be the only medium of instruction and not a foreign language.

Training through the medium of English have developed certain undesirable attitudes.

A few scholars may learn English language at the higher stages of education and keep the country in contact with the outside world.

A foreign language can be learnt effectively only after one has mastered the mother tongue.

The regional languages should also be learnt.

7. The Curriculum :

The school curriculum should be centred round, (1) the needs of the body, (2) voice training-pronunciation, recitation and understanding, (3) Udyog, (4) Atma jnan; how to conduct oneself with others, how to make oneself useful to all, how to control the senses, knowledge of the social and natural environment, knowledge of the distinction between the body and the soul.

8 Correlation :

Correlation should be effected through various channels to be full and complete

Correlation is the method according to which knowledge and action are so intimately integrated that one cannot say at any moment whether what is going on in the school is knowledge or work.

9. School Subjects :

Social studies should be taught in relation to the social and economic problems of the community.

History should be re-written and taught so as to promote unity in the country and to enable pupils to understand the continuity of tradition and its greatness.

In teaching history let not our children be taught hatred and narrow patriotism and one-sided truth.

Science should be taught in relation to the life and needs of the people.

Everyone should have a knowledge of the science of health, cleanliness, of the four elements, dietetics etc.

Tools and implements should be improved through the use of science.

Science is necessary, but it should be wedded to ahimsa.

Science and atma jnan should proceed hand in hand.

Children should be trained in art expression by making them live in the midst of nature.

Painting and drawing should be taught without elaborate equipment. Much of the equipment should be improvised by children.

10. Methodology :

Sense-training is an important first step for the acquisition of knowledge.

The children should be taught and trained in the activities of sitting, standing, eating, sleeping, walking etc.

The students should be trained well in methods of acquiring knowledge independently.

They should be helped to think for themselves, to aspire to follow truth wherever it may lead them and not to go along a beaten track. They should be trained to get confidence in their powers.

The Socratic method should be employed while children are being trained to acquire knowledge.

Children should learn the finest lines of poetry by rote. The learning of great passages of literature is an aid to the maturing of the soul.

11. Text Books :

Books occupy a secondary place in Nai Talim. State control of text books cuts at the roots of education.

A single text book for all standards is un-education.

12. Vacations and Holidays :

School Vacations cannot be the same all over the country. They should be in tune with the life and activities of the people and national requirements, and environment.

Long vacations have no meaning.

In ancient tradition holidays were meant to keep the mind detached from routine.

Holidays were days of resolve and service.

Days of saints and prophets should be observed as days of sat sankalpa and subha chintan.

13. Students :

(a) Training our students in methods of material comfort and ease is not the way to educate them.

Self-control, bodily efficiency and early rising have to be cultivated by all students.

Students should practise self-control and concentration and control of speech. Ekagratha leads to chittashuddhi. No knowledge is possible without concentrated study.

The test of Nai Talim is to find out whether boys have developed honesty, fearlessness, samatva and namratva Education is vinaya.

(b) The students should develop serious-mindedness. They should be in touch with all affairs of the world and develop an attitude of objectivity.

The secret of service is to render it in a limited area with an expansive vision.

(c) Students should have a thorough knowledge of democracy based on loka-neethi. They should not ally themselves with party-politics.

(d) Military training of youth does not produce healthy well-balanced personalities. It does not promote responsibility, freedom and self-determination.

(e) The indiscipline we find among students has to be sublimated through srama nishta.

(f) Travelling on foot from place to place (pada yatra) is an excellent method of education.

14. Punishment and Indiscipline :

Corporal punishment must not be employed in schools, since it breeds the attitude of fear in children.

Patient discussion, affection and love should be employed to counter indiscipline.

Education should produce fearless souls. Discipline cannot come out of fear.

The relationship between the teacher and pupil should be founded on affection.

The training through methods of ahimsa should be practised at home and at school.

Failure in ethical conduct on the part of students should be a matter for pity and not for punishment.

We must lay the foundations of truthfulness and trust in our schools.

15. Education in the Village :

All villages must have schools.

Some schools should be experimental ones, in which the teachers put forth all their thinking and energy in order to test their ideas.

The school should not admit students whose parents desire to seek Government jobs.

The village schools should be planned and organised by the villages themselves.

The teacher should be given land for his personal cultivation, grain and other facilities. Every school should be allotted land for cultivation, out of which a fourth may be for the teacher.

The State government may offer physical facilities etc. to the schools with no strings attached.

The State may lay down the conditions that the school should not teach violence and communalism.

The village should choose the teacher it needs for the education of its children.

The ideal Nai Talim school does not need even a single paisa. The teacher goes to the village with his two hands, a clean mind and a clean heart.

The teacher will conduct a one-hour school for the children, and a Mahavidyalaya for the adults during the nights.

During the day he will attend to his bread labour.

The life, events and experiences of the village will be the medium for educating the children.

Complete education, from the lowest to the highest, is possible in the village. For the study of the science of life, of nature for social studies, ethics, philosophy and culture, there is nothing better than the villages.

Adult education of the villagers should be effected through village crafts and not through mere literacy

Education for the cities should be complementary to that of the villages.

It would be a waste of public funds to start four year basic schools. Every village should have a full course of education.

16. Religious Education :

Religious education is not a matter of instruction or book learning.

Sat-sangh is the most important matter.

The teacher should be a person of character.

Children should learn the sayings of great saints and prophets.

Sarva dharma samabhava should be developed.

Children should have many opportunities of behaving and acting truthfully.

Prayer should be in the mother tongue of the pupil.

The meaning of the prayer hymns should be understood by the pupils

17. Women's Education :

Women must be educated in the same way as men for jeevan sikshan and not for mere material comfort.

Women's education should consist of adhyatma Jnan, Udyog, study of language and literature

At the end of school education they should be attached to elderly experienced ladies with whom they should cultivate seva vritti

18. Public Schools :

Public schools are an anachronism in a socialistic democracy.

19. Education and the State :

Education must be free from State control. The students have to be educated in an atmosphere of freedom from outside interference.

Society should have direct control of education, not the State.

The wise men of society should have control of education.

The people are the highest authority. The State derives its power and authority from the people. Education must therefore be in the hands of the people.

If the country is to be saved from Hitlers and Mussonis, education should be free from State control.

State control leads to mechanical standardized pattern of education for the whole country. Education should not be set in a mould.

If education is independent and free, there would be a rich variety of curricular programmes.

The State should not prescribe text books for compulsory study in schools. This leads to indoctrination.

The State may offer general guidance and advice to educational institutions and leave it to them to accept it or not. The state may also suggest text books and curriculum, but should not enforce them.

Educational institutions must be free to offer the students the education they think best.

Education should be free from State control even as justice is.

20. State and Employment :

Service under government should not have anything to do with graduation.

The various departments of government may conduct their own examinations for choosing candidates on merit.

This method will encourage private effort in education, and discourage exodus from the village to the city.

Education which adds to the number of the unemployed is demoralizing.

The basic schools should take children whose parents do not want their children to seek government jobs.

21. Nai Talim and Gramdan :

The Nai Talim experiments may be taken up in Gramdan blocks.

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